



THE
**SANDWICH
PROJECT**

www.TheSandwichProject.org

TSP VOLUNTEER HANDBOOK

Nourish the Hungry. Feed the Soul.



Welcome to The Sandwich Project

Thank you for volunteering with The Sandwich Project (TSP). Whether you are making sandwiches, hosting a collection site, or delivering meals, you play a critical role in helping us feed our community with dignity and care.

This handbook provides the food safety guidelines and role-specific procedures that every TSP volunteer needs to follow. It is organized into two parts: first, the food safety principles that apply to everyone and explain why we do what we do; then, step-by-step instructions for your specific role.

Who We Serve

We serve children and students, veterans, seniors, low-income working individuals and families, and people who are living without permanent housing. Many of the people we serve also face additional challenges, such as health conditions, disabilities, limited access to transportation, and no healthcare insurance.



Our Volunteer Roles

We believe in the power of community, and each volunteer role is essential to our mission of feeding families with dignity.

Sandwich Makers: p. 12-15

Prepare fresh, safe sandwiches following food safety protocols.

Hosts: p. 16-19

Provide a central collection point for sandwich drop-offs and coordinate with drivers.

Drivers: p. 20

Transport sandwiches from host homes to distribution partners.

CRITICAL FOOD SAFETY NOTE: Anyone with food allergies should never consume TSP sandwiches.

Food Safety for All Volunteers

These food safety principles apply to every TSP volunteer—sandwich makers, hosts, and drivers alike. Understanding the reasoning behind our protocols will help you make informed decisions at every step, even when a situation is not covered by a specific rule.

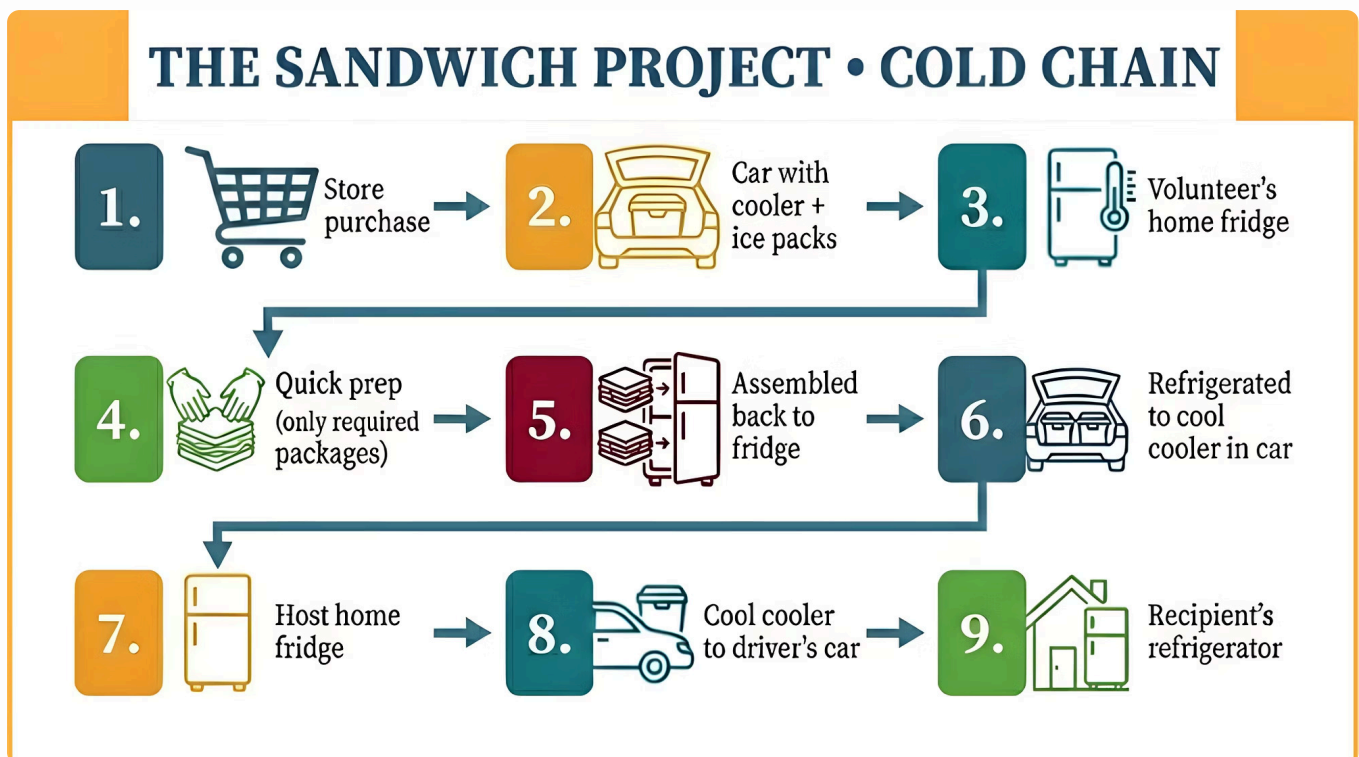
Why Food Safety Matters More for TSP

As an organization, we are subject to food safety laws. Additionally, since many of our recipients—children, seniors, pregnant women, people who are sick or immunocompromised—are more vulnerable to food-borne illness than most, and many have limited access to healthcare.

The Cold Chain

The "cold chain" means keeping perishable food consistently cold—below 39°F—from the moment it is purchased until the sandwich is delivered and eaten. Every link in the chain matters: store to car, car to fridge, fridge to sandwich prep, back to fridge, fridge to cooler, cooler to delivery.

If any link breaks, we cannot guarantee the food is safe, even if it "looks fine." The cold chain is maintained by every volunteer across every role. Sandwich makers maintain it during shopping and prep. Hosts maintain it during collection and storage. Drivers maintain it during transport.



Food Safety: The Two-Hour Rule

39°F

Highest Safe Temperature

This is the highest safe temperature for deli meat and cheese. Above this temperature, bacterial growth begins.

80°F

Absolute Limit

Deli meat must never reach this temperature. Once it does, it must be discarded.

Understanding the Cumulative Nature of the Two-Hour Rule

Deli meat and cheese may only be above 39°F for a total of two hours, cumulatively. This is NOT two hours at a time—the time adds up across the entire process from factory to consumer.



Shopping

Bringing a cooler to the store keeps ingredients cold from the moment you check out to the moment they reach your refrigerator.



Prep

Taking out only one package of meat and one package of cheese at a time keeps everything else cold while you assemble each loaf.



Transport

Using a cooler to transport your sandwiches to the host home keeps them cold and protects what is left of that two-hour window.



Every step adds to the total. If the food has been above 39°F for a total of two hours, it must be discarded. Re-cooling does NOT kill bacteria that have already grown.

Food Safety: Refrigeration

The people we serve are counting on us. Your attention to these rules is one of the most important things you can do as a volunteer.

Temperature Range

Refrigerators must consistently maintain a temperature between **34°–38°F**.

Air Circulation

Adequate air circulation is essential for the refrigerator to actually cool its contents. Do not block fans.

Never Overfill

Overfilled refrigerators can compromise airflow and create warm spots, compromising food safety.

Door Discipline

Refrigeration should remain closed at all times except for brief access to add or remove sandwiches or ingredients, as temperatures rise quickly, especially in hot weather.

Freezer Use

To make sandwiches extra cold for hot-weather distribution, the freezer may be used briefly – limit to 15–20 minutes.

Storage Best Practices

- Ensure all items are properly labeled before refrigerating.
- Monitor refrigerator temperature regularly.
- Rarrange/remove food items to maximize space for sandwiches and ensure proper cooling



Cooler Safety Protocols

Coolers Are Not Refrigerators

Unlike refrigerators, coolers do not circulate cold air to actively lower the temperature of food.

Coolers keep cold food cold. They preserve cold temperatures, but do not lower them.

Do not place food into a warm cooler. A cooler is considered warm if the inside feels room temperature or warmer. Add frozen ice packs and close the lid until the interior feels cold to the touch before putting food in the cooler.

TSP SANDWICH COOLER LAYOUT



Food Safety: Coolers & Transport

Coolers Work For:

Getting sandwich ingredients home from the grocery store.

Transporting pre-chilled sandwiches packed tightly with ice packs.

Properly packed coolers can maintain safe temperatures for up to one hour during active transport.

Coolers DO NOT Work For:

Bringing the temperature of **warm food** down.

Storing cold food for **long periods of time**.

Making warm food **safe again** by **recooling**.

Maximizing Cooler Performance & Safe Transport

Pack quickly

To keep warm air out, coolers should be packed quickly and closed between trips to the refrigerator for loaves. Keep your cooler in the shade while packing!

Place Ice Packs

Place ice packs between rows of sandwich loaves. Make sure all sandwiches are in contact with ice packs.

Pack Full with Minimal Free Space

Coolers with minimal air space stay colder longer than partially filled ones.

Keep Lid Closed Tightly

Every time you open a cooler, warm air enters. Do not open coolers during transport.

Critical Transport Safety

Keep coolers in the vehicle cabin where A/C circulates, never in the trunk, which lacks airflow and heats up quickly. Trunks can reach extreme temperatures, creating a high-risk environment for perishable food.

Food Safety: Shopping and Storage Standards

Use Prepackaged Deli Meat/Cheese Only



Never use products sliced at the deli counter.

Check Expiration Dates



"Use by" date must be **at least 7 days** after drop-off.

When shopping for ingredients, bring a cooler with ice packs to the store, park in the shade, and place ingredients in coolers for the ride home. Do not make any stops; go straight home.

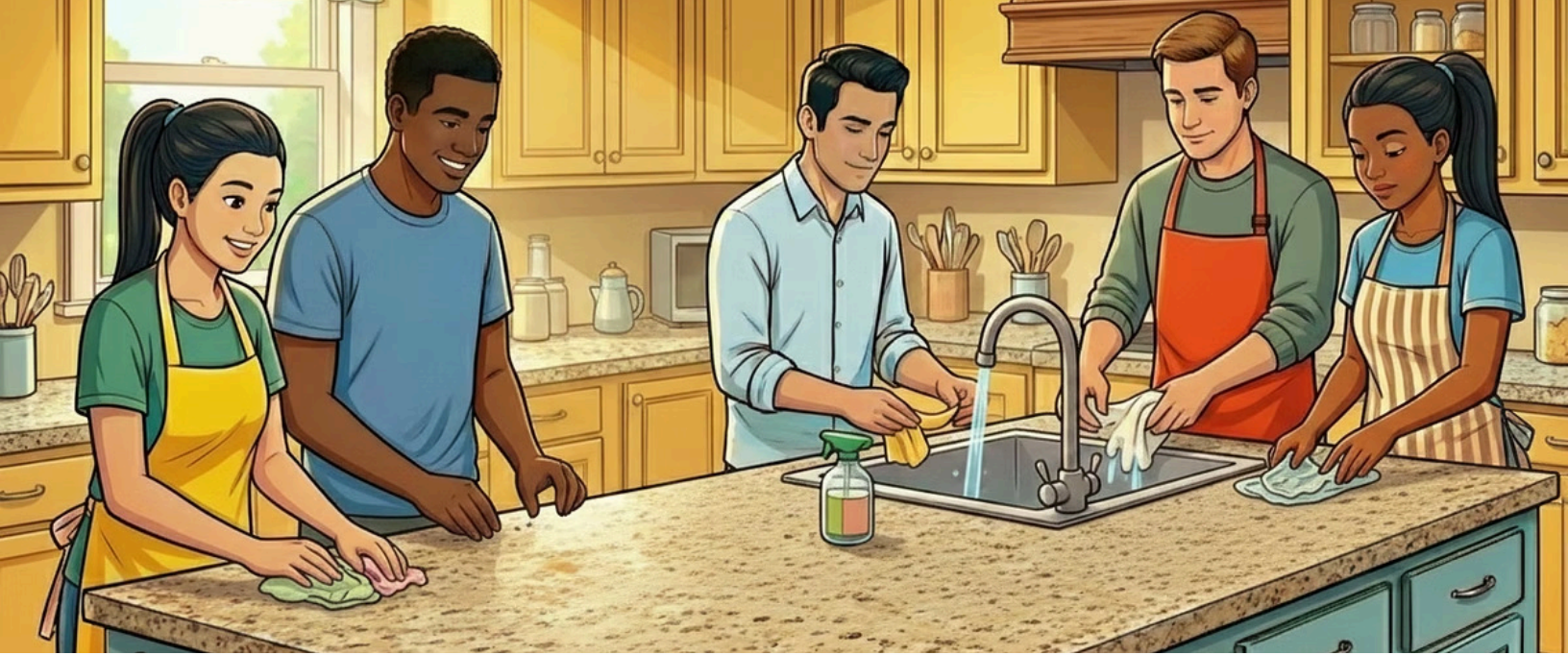
TSP Accepts Only Unopened Sandwich Ingredients

Sandwich makers with **unopened** leftover ingredients may drop them off at a host home. We will donate them to groups who would like to make more sandwiches than their budget allows.

Two-Week Maximum

Use all **unopened** packages of meat/cheese **within 2 weeks of purchase**, regardless of the expiration date.

Once opened, discard any unused meat within 24 hours.



Food Safety: Sandwich Prep/Assembly

Clean Surfaces

Clean counters and wash utensils. Store personal items out of reach. Cover your table/counter with a disposable tablecloth for easy cleanup.

Hair Restraint

Tie back hair (including bangs) or use a hairnet; use beard nets for facial hair. Do this before handwashing.

Handwashing

Wash hands with soap and water before starting prep work, during as necessary, and after all prep work is complete in preparation for sandwich making.

Hand sanitizer is unsafe for food handling, as alcohol residue can transfer to gloves and food, and it does not remove all bacteria, food residue, or contaminants.

Food-Safe Gloves

After surfaces and hands are clean and hair is restrained, put on **food-safe gloves**. Change gloves after touching **anything** other than your sandwich ingredients, including your cell phone.

Food Safety: Labels & Compliance

Contains Nuts

OF SANDWICHES _____

☐ WORE GLOVES

☐ KEPT REFRIGERATED

INITIAL: _____

PREPARED ON: _____

THE SANDWICH PROJECT
PB&J

Contains Nuts

TYPE OF MEAT: _____

OF SANDWICHES _____

☐ WORE GLOVES

☐ KEPT REFRIGERATED

INITIAL: _____

PREPARED ON: _____

THE SANDWICH PROJECT
DELI

Keep refrigerated. Use within four days of prepared date.
May contain nuts, or have been produced in a kitchen containing nuts.

Label Requirements

Use only TSP-issued labels (to print at home, click on the image of the labels you need above).

Fill out all required information, including type of meat.

Time Limits

Sandwiches must be **consumed within 4 days** of the date made (see label).

Spoilage

Bread and sandwich ingredients should appear fresh and free from mold or other spoilage. However, not all spoilage is visible or has a detectable odor, so careful handling is essential.

The most important thing to remember is that The Sandwich Project serves our neighbors who are experiencing food insecurity, with a focus on dignity, nourishment, and meeting people where they are.

Sandwich Maker Guidelines

Preparing Safe, Fresh Sandwiches

As a sandwich maker, you purchase ingredients, prepare sandwiches, and deliver them to a host home—you are responsible for the first several links of the cold chain, from the grocery store through assembly and drop-off.

Shopping for Ingredients

- **Bring a cooler with ice packs to the store.** Park in the shade. Pick up deli items last (remember: the two-hour clock starts the moment they leave the store's refrigerated case). Place them in the cooler for the ride home. Go straight home—no stops.
- **Use only prepackaged deli meat and cheese.** Never use products sliced at the deli counter.
 - Sliced American cheese (do not use individually wrapped processed "cheese product" such as Kraft Singles)
 - Prepackaged deli-style turkey or chicken
 - Use a minimum of 2 ounces of deli meat per sandwich.
 - See your package's label to find out how many slices make up one serving size. For packages labeled in grams: 56g = 2 oz.
 - White wheat bread, do not use heels of loaf
 - Do NOT add lettuce, tomato, mayo, mustard, or any condiments.
- **For PBJ sandwiches:**
 - **Peanut butter:** use only smooth peanut butter, no alternative nut butters
 - **Jelly:** only strawberry or grape; use jelly, not jam, preserves, or fruit spreads
- **Check expiration dates.** Choose products with the furthest dates available. The "use by" date must be at least 7 days after your drop-off date.
- **Buy quality.** Purchase the same quality ingredients you would feed your own family.
- **Refrigerate immediately upon arriving home.** Meat and cheese go straight into the fridge.

Sandwich-Making Safety

Setting Up Your Workspace

- Clean counters and wash utensils. Cover your work surface with a disposable tablecloth for easy prep and cleanup.
- Tie back hair longer than chin-length or use hairnets.
- Wash hands with soap and water, then put on food-safe gloves. Change gloves if you touch anything other than food ingredients.

Working in Batches (Maintaining the Cold Chain)

This is where the two-hour rule matters most. Every minute meat spends outside the fridge counts toward that cumulative two-hour limit:

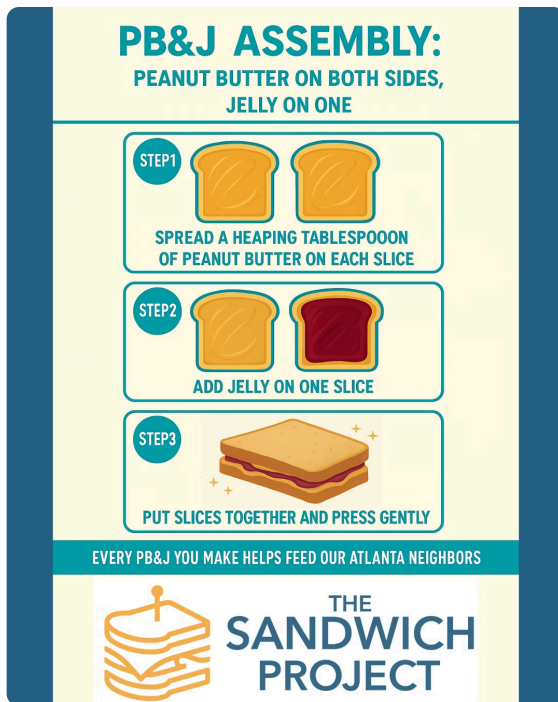
- Make one loaf of sandwiches at a time, which allows you to take only one package of meat and one package of cheese from the fridge at a time.
- Immediately return the completed loaf to the refrigerator before starting the next.
- If working with a team, divide tasks: some people assemble sandwiches while others pack completed sandwiches, take finished loaves to the refrigerator, and retrieve additional meat/cheese as needed.

Cross-Contamination Prevention

- Do not leave open containers of peanut butter or nut/shellfish products near deli ingredients.
- Use separate knives for jelly and peanut butter.
- Use disposable spatulas for scooping/spreading peanut butter and jelly to avoid mess and cross-contamination.

Sandwich Assembly Standards

Before you start: Save the bread bag and twist tie from your loaf – you'll need it at the end.

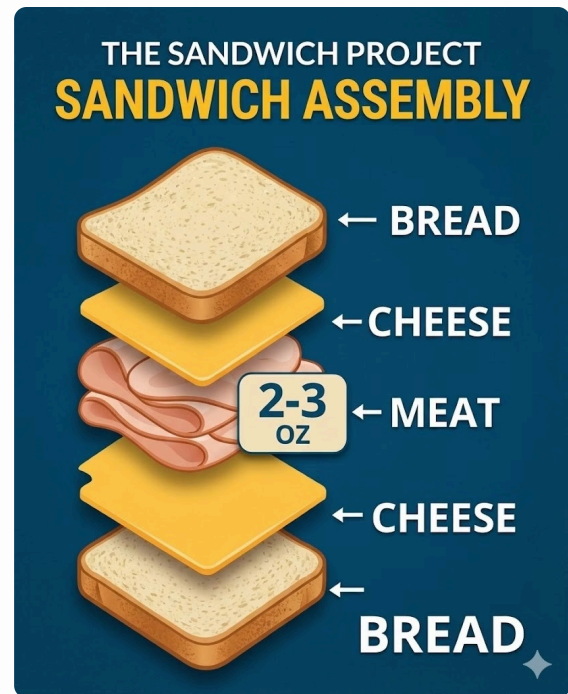


PB&J Sandwich Standards

1. Use disposable spatulas for scooping and spreading peanut butter/jelly to avoid mess and cross-contamination.
2. Spread 1½ tablespoon of smooth peanut butter (do not use crunchy, light, or reduced-fat) on each slice of bread.
3. Spread 2 teaspoons of strawberry or grape jelly only (not jam, preserves, or fruit spread) on top of the peanut butter on one slice.
4. Press one plain peanut butter slice and one slice with jelly together gently.

To finish your sandwiches:

1. Place each assembled sandwich in an individual sandwich bag. Remove excess air and seal.
2. Return bagged sandwiches to the bread loaf bag. Remove excess air and secure with the twist tie.



Deli Sandwich Standards

1. Place 1 slice of cheese on each side of the bread (2 slices total).
2. Place meat slices on half of all the slices of bread that you've topped with cheese.
3. Combine a slice of bread with only cheese with a slice of bread that has both cheese and meat on them to create one whole sandwich.

Transporting Sandwiches to Host Homes

Sandwiches must be made on Wednesday, or Tuesday evening if necessary.

Never make sandwiches before Tuesday evening.

Deliver to your host home within 24 hours of preparation—ideally as soon as possible after making them.

Use Proper Cooling

Use a cooler packed tightly with ice packs — enough to keep sandwiches refrigerator cold.

Never Transport Warm Sandwiches

Always chill sandwiches in the refrigerator before placing them in a cooler.

Direct Transport

Go directly to your host home — no stops along the way.

Use TSP Labels

At the host home, attach the correct TSP label (Deli or PB&J) and fill out all fields.

Sign In On The Sign-In Sheet

Sign in with your name, contact info, and sandwich count and type.



Host Guidelines

As a host, you are a central collection point for sandwiches. As such, you are the quality control checkpoint between sandwich makers and drivers—verifying that everything coming in appears safe and properly handled, and ensuring everything going out has been kept cold and is ready for transport.

Key Responsibilities

- Provide a clean, organized collection area with adequate refrigeration.
- Greet volunteers warmly and thank them so that they feel a part of the TSP family.
- Inspect incoming sandwiches for proper temperature, packaging, and labeling.
- Maintain sign-in sheets and report sandwich counts to your lead host.
- Prepare coolers and deliver sandwiches to recipient organizations or coordinate with drivers for Thursday deliveries.
- Report any food safety concerns to Marcy.

Materials Provided by TSP

Coolers & Ice Packs

Insulated coolers and reusable ice packs for maintaining temperature during transport. These are not for storage of sandwiches outside of transportation— all sandwiches must be refrigerated while at your home.

Collection Site Signage

Signs to help volunteers identify your home as an "official TSP collection location." Several of our sandwich-makers and drivers alike have mentioned how helpful your signs are for finding where they need to go.

Sign-In Sheets

Printed sheets for volunteers to record their names, contact information, and sandwich types and numbers.

TSP Labels

Official labels for volunteers to fill out and attach to their prepared sandwiches (separate PB&J and Deli labels).

Additional Materials:

The Sandwich Project has its own web app! It is easy to get started. Katie will email login information and get you started before your first collection day!

Access at www.TSPapp.org

Collection Site Setup & Maintenance

Wednesday: Collection Day Prep

Put Out Donation Bin

Place in an easily accessible location for fruit and/or snack collections.

Prepare Sign-In Station

Place sign-in sheets, both deli & PB&J labels, and pens on a table near the drop-off area.

Organize Sandwich Labels

Keep deli and PB&J labels separate and readily available.

Place TSP Yard Sign

Position prominently for easy site identification by volunteers.

Safe Transportation

Remind volunteers to deliver cold sandwiches in **cooler bags with ice packs** to maintain proper temperature during transport.

Weekly Newsletter

Remind your sandwich makers to sign up for our weekly newsletter: host vacation dates, TSP vacation weeks, and other pertinent information.

Check Labels

Date on labels should be no earlier than **Tuesday evening (preferably Wednesday)**.

Collection Site Hygiene

Coolers

Wash coolers with **soap and warm water** after use.

Allow coolers to **fully air-dry** before storing. Once dry, **immediately close lid tightly**.

Use only dedicated TSP coolers for sandwiches.

Refrigerator

Clean refrigerator **regularly**.

Remove all personal food items.

Close the refrigerator door between each placement of sandwiches. Minimize the amount of time the door remains open while loading.

Garage/Collection Area

Keep the collection area **clean, uncluttered, and free of strong odors**.

Store all food, coolers, and ice packs **off the floor**.

Keep food away from *pets, trash, chemicals, and tools*.

Wednesday Protocol: Collection & Storage

Volunteer Arrival

Greet volunteers at your sign-in station. A warm greeting helps sandwich makers feel welcome and want to stay connected.

Volunteers Sign In

Volunteers sign in and record sandwich counts and contact information.

Sandwich Labeling

Make sure TSP-provided labels are filled out and applied to all loaves.

Receive and Inspect Sandwiches

Check that sandwiches are sealed and cold to the touch. Place in refrigerator without crushing or crowding.

Handling Quality Issues

Open/Torn Bags

Check that loaf bags are securely closed with twist ties. Transfer sandwiches to a new bag if the outer bag is torn. Ensure the sandwiches themselves are still properly sealed and intact.

Missing Labels

Confirm all loaves have a complete, legible TSP label on the outer bag – not on individual sandwich bags. No other labels or stickers should be added.

When to Contact Your Lead Host

Sandwiches that feel warm or have been left unrefrigerated
Damaged or improperly sealed packaging
Missing or incomplete labels
Any concerns about food safety or quality

When Sandwiches Cannot Be Accepted

Set Aside Problem Sandwiches

1. Isolate them immediately. Mark the bags clearly with **"Do Not Use"** and a brief reason (e.g., **"Warm," "Open Bag," "Unsafe"**).
2. Contact your lead host for urgent instructions on disposal.

Thursday Protocol: Delivery & Transport

Ensure Coolers Are Clean and Cool

Check the coolers are clean and the interior feels cool to the touch before loading sandwiches.

Layer Ice Packs between Sandwiches

Place ice packs between sandwich loaves and around cooler sides. All loaves should be in contact with an ice pack.

Keep in Vehicle Cabin

Transport coolers inside the vehicle cabin, not the trunk.

Deliver Promptly

Take coolers straight to the designated destination without stopping on the way.

Refrigerate Immediately

Transfer sandwiches to a refrigerator as soon as they arrive at their destination.

Important Transport Rules

TSP Use Only

To prevent cross-contamination, coolers used for TSP sandwiches **should not** be used for any other purpose.

For example, do not use the same cooler for raw meat, fish, or other items.

Never Pack a Hot Cooler

Empty coolers stored in hot conditions must be brought inside to **cool completely** before packing.

Pack Cooler Tightly

Coolers with little free space stay cold more effectively.

Close Lids Tightly and Keep Them Closed

Ensure lids are closed quickly after packing and sealed tightly. Leave them closed—the goal is to have the cooler open for as little time as possible.

Do Not Leave Coolers in Your Vehicle

Packed coolers must **NEVER be left in vehicles**—only for use during active transport.

Food Allergy Alert

Anyone with any food allergies should never consume any TSP sandwiches. They are not safe for people with food allergies.

Driver Guidelines

As a driver, you are the final link in the cold chain. Your job is to get sandwiches from host homes to recipient organizations quickly, safely, and at the right temperature.

Before Your First Delivery

- **Sign the Vehicle Release Form.** All drivers must complete this before their first delivery. Contact Jordan (Driver Coordinator) at 770-789-7329 if you have not received one.
- **Understand our delivery partners.** We deliver exclusively to **501(c)(3) organizations**. We cannot hand sandwiches directly to individuals.

Transport Protocol

- Pre-cool your vehicle with the A/C before loading.
- Verify sandwiches and coolers are cold before loading. If a cooler feels warm or sandwiches are not cold to the touch, do not transport them—contact the host or your lead.
- Check that ice packs are layered between loaves and on top, and that coolers are packed tightly with minimal air space.
- Close cooler lids immediately when finished packing. Do not open coolers during transport.
- Keep coolers in the vehicle cabin where A/C circulates—never in the trunk.
- Drive directly to the delivery location. No stops.
- Transfer sandwiches to a refrigerator immediately upon arrival at the recipient organization.
- Communicate any delays to the recipient organization right away.



Frequently Asked Questions

Food Safety & Best Practices

The following Q&A addresses common questions from our volunteers about food safety, ingredient selection, and best practices.

TEMPERATURE & SAFETY

Q: How can I keep deli sandwiches safe during preparation?

A: To keep sandwiches safe, get deli meat back into the refrigerator as quickly as possible at each step, and never leave it out longer than necessary.

Q: What if I am not sure how long meat has been out?

A: When in doubt, throw it out. If you cannot confidently say the deli meat has been out for less than two hours total, it is safer to discard it.

INGREDIENTS

Q: What kind of meat should I buy for deli sandwiches?

A: Please use only prepackaged deli-sliced turkey or chicken.

Q: Why can I not buy meat and cheese sliced at the deli counter?

A: Prepackaged deli meat is safer than meat sliced at a retail counter because it is processed and sealed in a controlled environment. Meat sliced at a deli counter can be exposed to shared equipment and handling, which increases the risk of contamination.

Q: What kind of cheese is **not** acceptable?

A: Do not use individually wrapped slices or processed “cheese product” such as Kraft Singles. These products are less nutritious and soften or “melt” quickly on sandwiches. Please use real sliced cheese instead.

Q: What type of peanut butter is required for PBJ sandwiches?

A:: Use smooth peanut butter only. Crunchy, light, or reduced-fat varieties make messy sandwiches or provide sub-optimal nutrition and are not requested by recipient organizations.

Q: What kind of jelly should I use?

A: Use strawberry or grape jelly only. Do NOT use jam, preserves, or fruit spread.

Q: Can I add other condiments or vegetables to the sandwiches?

A: No. For deli sandwiches, we ask for only bread, meat, and cheese; for PBJ, just bread, peanut butter, and jelly are needed. No other condiments or vegetables should be added. We accept donations of condiment packets via our Amazon wishlist that are delivered with our sandwiches for individuals to add as they desire.

SHOPPING & STORAGE

Q: How do I pick the right expiration date for ingredients?

A: Always buy the latest expiration date you can find at the store. The date you are dropping off your sandwiches must be at least 7 days before the "use by" date on all ingredients.

ASSEMBLY

Q: How much meat should go on a deli sandwich?

A: Each deli sandwich should have a minimum of 2 ounces of meat. Check the serving size on the package; thinner sliced meats often require 3-4 slices to meet the minimum. For packages that list grams, 56g is equivalent to 2 ounces.

Q: How many slices of cheese go on each sandwich?

A: 2 slices: one on either side of the meat

Q: Do I put peanut butter on both sides of the PBJ sandwich?

A: Yes, 1.5 tbsp of smooth peanut butter on both sides of bread, and 2 tsp of jelly on one.

PACKAGING

Q: How do I bag the sandwiches after assembly?

A: Each sandwich should be placed in its own sandwich-size Ziploc bag. Gently squeeze out any excess air without smushing the sandwich, then seal the bag. Finally, stack the bagged sandwiches back into the original bread bag, again squeeze out excess air and close it with the original twist tie.

Q: Why is it important to put the bagged sandwiches back into the bread bag?

A: Using the original bread bag makes the sandwiches easy to store, count, and transport efficiently.

Q: Can I tape or tie the bread bag shut?

A: No, only use the twist ties to close the bread bag. You can purchase extras or your host home should have some when you drop off your sandwiches.

Contact Information

TSP Team Contacts:

Driver Coordinator: Jordan | **770-789-7329**

Web App & More: Katie | **770-789-1013**

Executive Director: Christine Cooper Nowicki | **(404) 786-8116**

Safety Committee & Co-Founder | Marcy **(678) 596-9697**

Website: thesandwichproject.org

Email: info@thesandwichproject.org

Your Lead Host:

Name: _____

Phone #: _____

Email: _____